

Roots to Wings

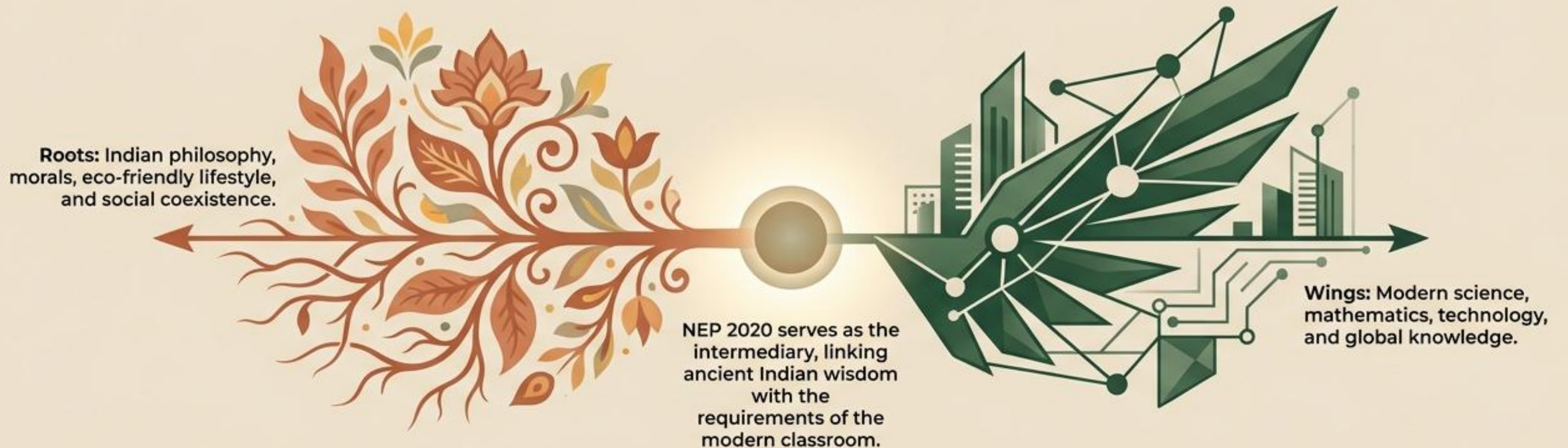
Integrating Indian
Knowledge Systems in
Modern Teacher Education



Rootedness balances cultural origins with modern global progress

In a globalized world where students are constantly exposed to external technologies and philosophies, knowing one's cultural and intellectual heritage is imperative for identity construction.

Rootedness in Indian education is not a retreat into the past. It is the ability to tie our educational frameworks to indigenous cultural origins while advancing confidently in a modern world.



The Indian Knowledge System spans millennia of diverse intellectual traditions.

IKS is an interconnected web of wisdom, science, and pedagogy originating in the Indian subcontinent.



Early Foundations: The Guru-Shishya tradition emphasizing dialogue and reverence. Ancient texts mention female scholars like Gargi and Maitreyi.

Linguistics & Philosophy: The four Vedas and Upanishads formed the ethical base.



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Mathematics & Astronomy: Aryabhata utilized the place value system, and Brahmagupta formalized the use of zero.

Health & Anatomy: Charaka documented internal medicine, while Sushruta detailed surgical methods.



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Institutional Learning: Centers like Nalanda and Takshashila fostered multidisciplinary study.

Modern philosophical titans championed holistic, child-centered learning

The foundations of modern Indian educational reform were laid by visionary thinkers who sought to develop the whole individual.



Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar

Inclusive education as a tool for social reform; accessibility for women and simplified learning materials.



Swami Vivekananda

Character building and the manifestation of the perfection already in man.



Rabindranath Tagore

Joyful, stress-free learning in harmony with nature; opposed rigid, exam-oriented systems.



Mahatma Gandhi

Nai Talim (Basic Education); learning through productive work, dignity of labour, and self-reliance.



Sri Aurobindo

Integral Education; developing physical, emotional, mental, psychic, and spiritual dimensions.



J. Krishnamurti

Freedom from fear and competition; true learning through dialogue, inquiry, and deep self-awareness.

Decolonisation restores epistemic balance and plurality

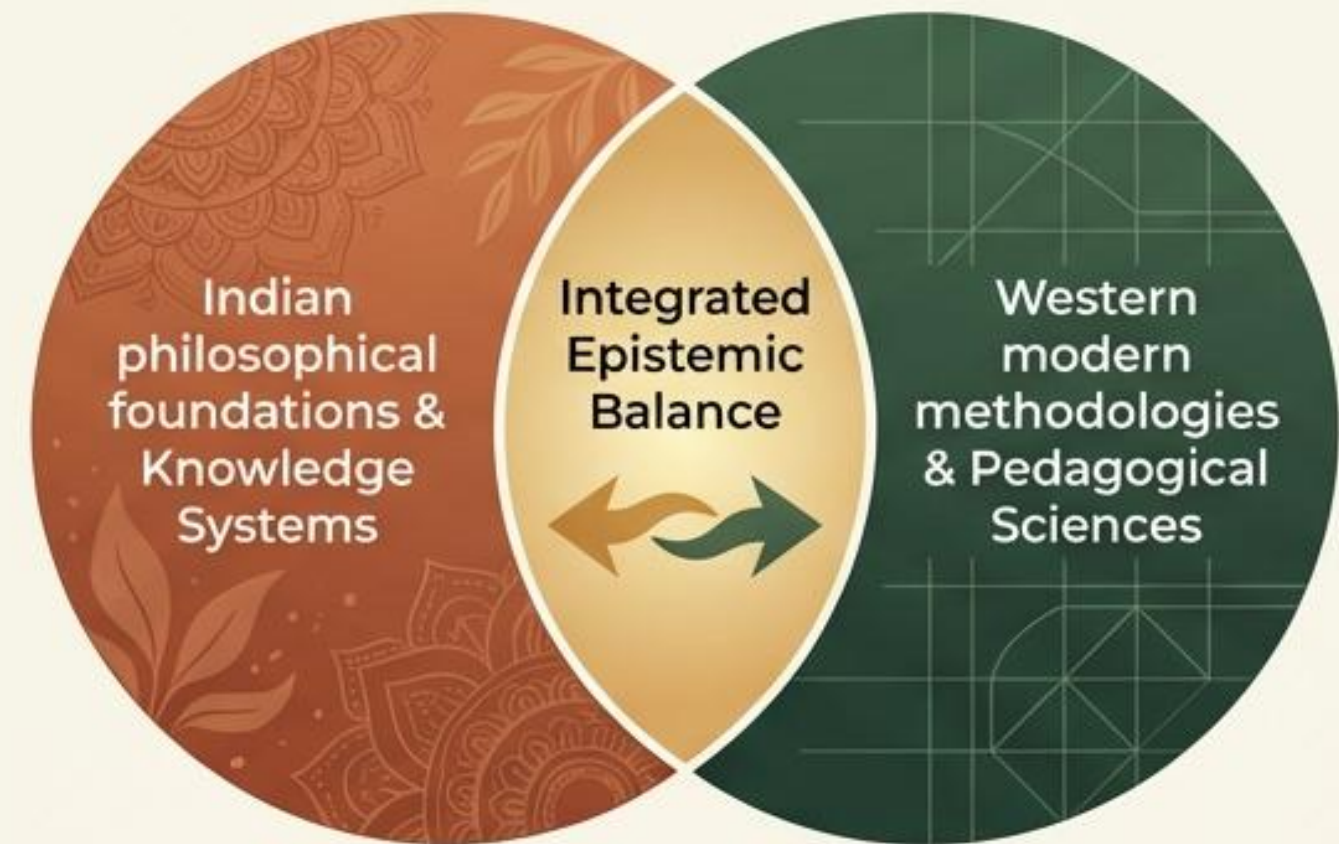
Colonial education introduced valuable models of administration and modernization, but it systematically marginalized indigenous knowledge traditions, creating a disconnect from India's socio-cultural realities.

Decolonisation in teacher education involves questioning why certain knowledge systems are considered universal while others are labeled local. It requires scholarly engagement, research, and thoughtful integration—not symbolic or emotionally driven rejection of the West.

COLONIAL LEGACY

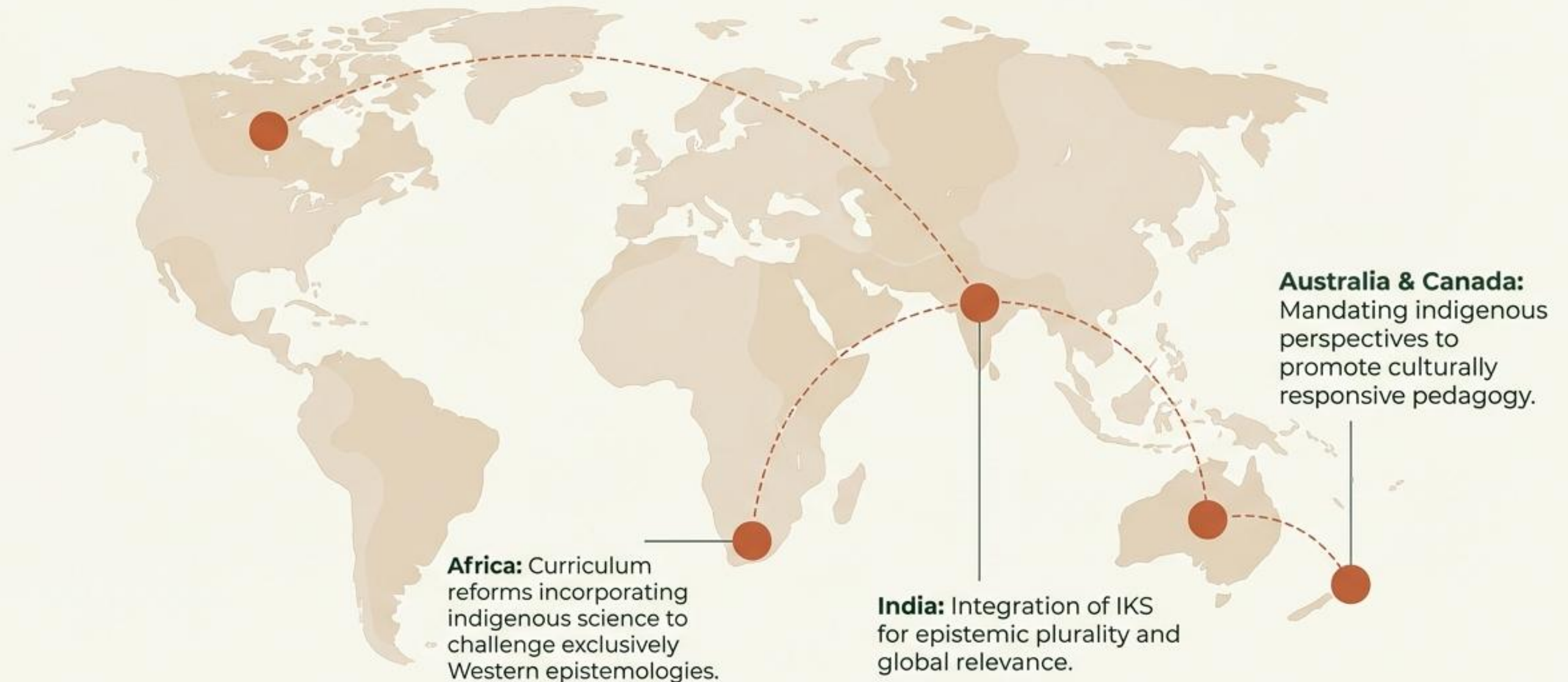


DECOLONISED VISION



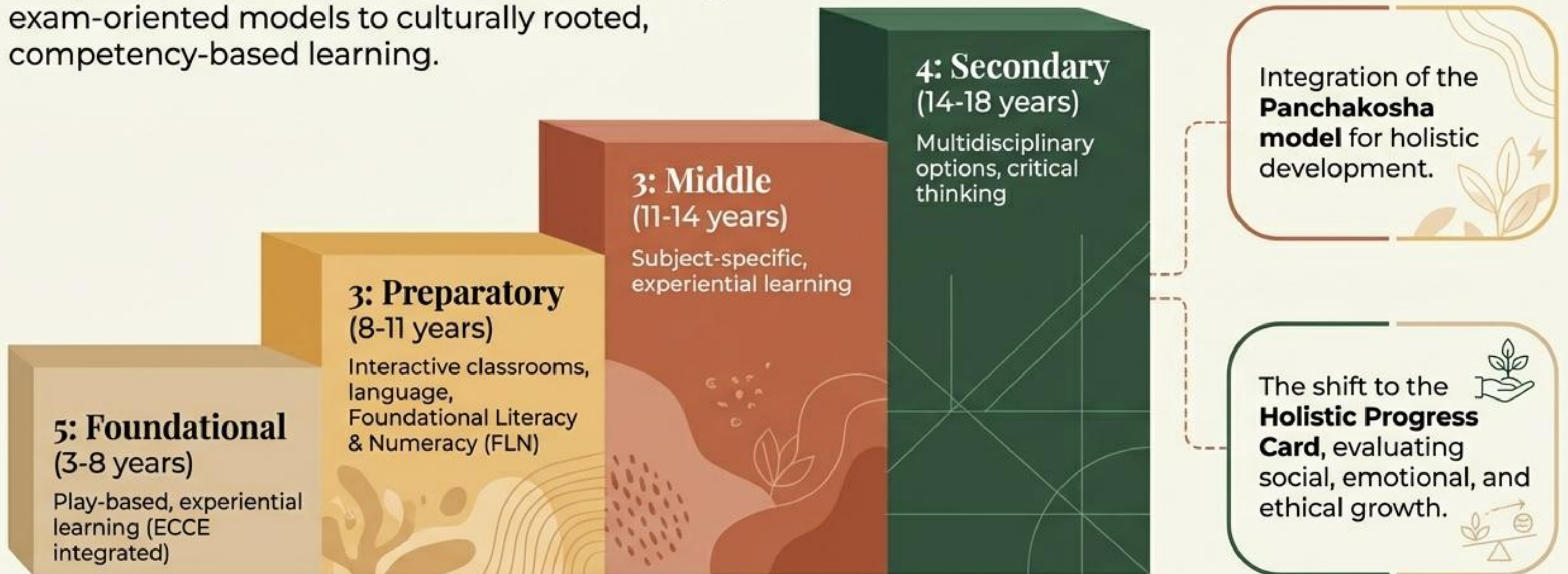
Epistemic plurality is a recognized global educational movement

India's integration of IKS aligns directly with an international shift toward decolonization and the recognition of culturally situated knowledge systems.



NEP 2020 and NCF 2023 structurally align education with developmental stages.

Policy has shifted the focus from content-heavy, exam-oriented models to culturally rooted, competency-based learning.



Educational reform relies entirely on the empowered teacher

Policies and curriculum frameworks provide direction, but real change requires the teacher. NEP 2020 recognizes teachers as the heart of the learning process.

IKS is not merely supplementary content; it is a **fundamental way of thinking**. Teacher education provides the academic structure, while IKS brings ethical grounding.



Integration requires embedding IKS organically across core disciplines

Meaningful integration cannot be achieved by inserting a single optional paper. It requires moving beyond standalone electives toward an integrated curriculum design.



Authentic integration relies on prepared faculty and community partnerships

Faculty Development & Academic Orientation

Educators must engage with IKS in a critical and informed manner.

Interdisciplinary workshops, research, and rigorous study of primary texts ensure deep conceptual clarity.

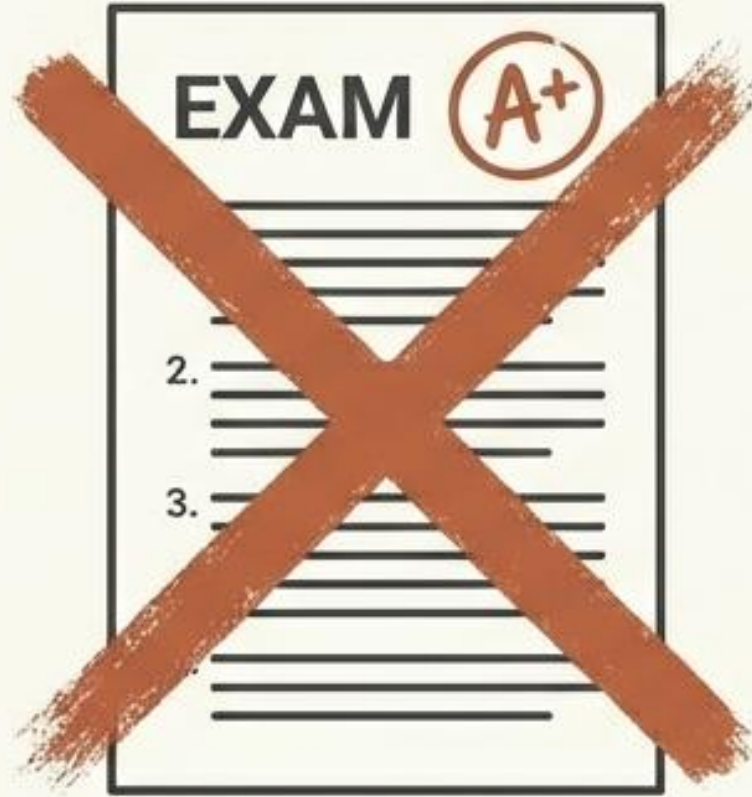


Authentic Teacher Preparation

Community Collaboration

Bridging the gap between theory and lived practice. Inviting traditional artisans, yoga practitioners, and local experts provides experiential understanding rather than abstract instruction.

Assessment and language must adapt to reflect multidimensional growth



Holistic Assessment Practices

Moving beyond examination systems **relying** solely on rote memorization. Adopting reflective journals, portfolio-based assessments, and community engagement tasks.



Multilingual Engagement

Traditional texts are tied to Indian languages. Multilingualism allows trainees to access knowledge authentically and build linguistic confidence.

Current implementation remains transitional and uneven across institutions

While the NEP 2020 policy mandate is strong, research indicates that translation into **institutional practice** requires deliberate structural changes.

Research-Based Observations on IKS Implementation

POLICY VISION VS. INSTITUTIONAL REALITY	
Curriculum Integration	IKS is frequently introduced as electives rather than embedded across core subjects. (Mahesh et al., 2023)
Teacher Preparation	There is limited structured training in IKS pedagogy for teacher educators. (Dyer et al., 2004)
Curriculum Reform	Institutional resistance and lack of resources slow necessary curriculum realignment. (Booi & Khuzwayo, 2018)
Community Collaboration	Research stresses an urgent need for engagement with indigenous knowledge holders. (Tailby et al., 2020)

Structural and academic roadblocks threaten meaningful reform

Several practical challenges impede the deep integration of Indian Knowledge Systems:

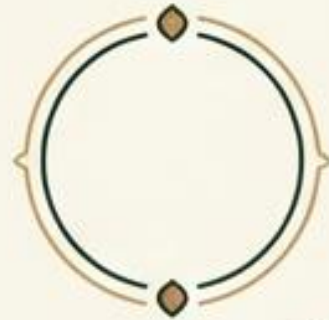
Faculty Preparedness

Educators trained primarily in Western theoretical frameworks lack formal exposure to IKS.



The Risk of Tokenism

Simply adding a single chapter without systemic pedagogical reform leads to symbolic inclusion, not transformation.



Academic Rigor & Ideology

Avoiding the extremes of celebrating traditions unreflectively or viewing them as anti-modern. Requires scholarly engagement.



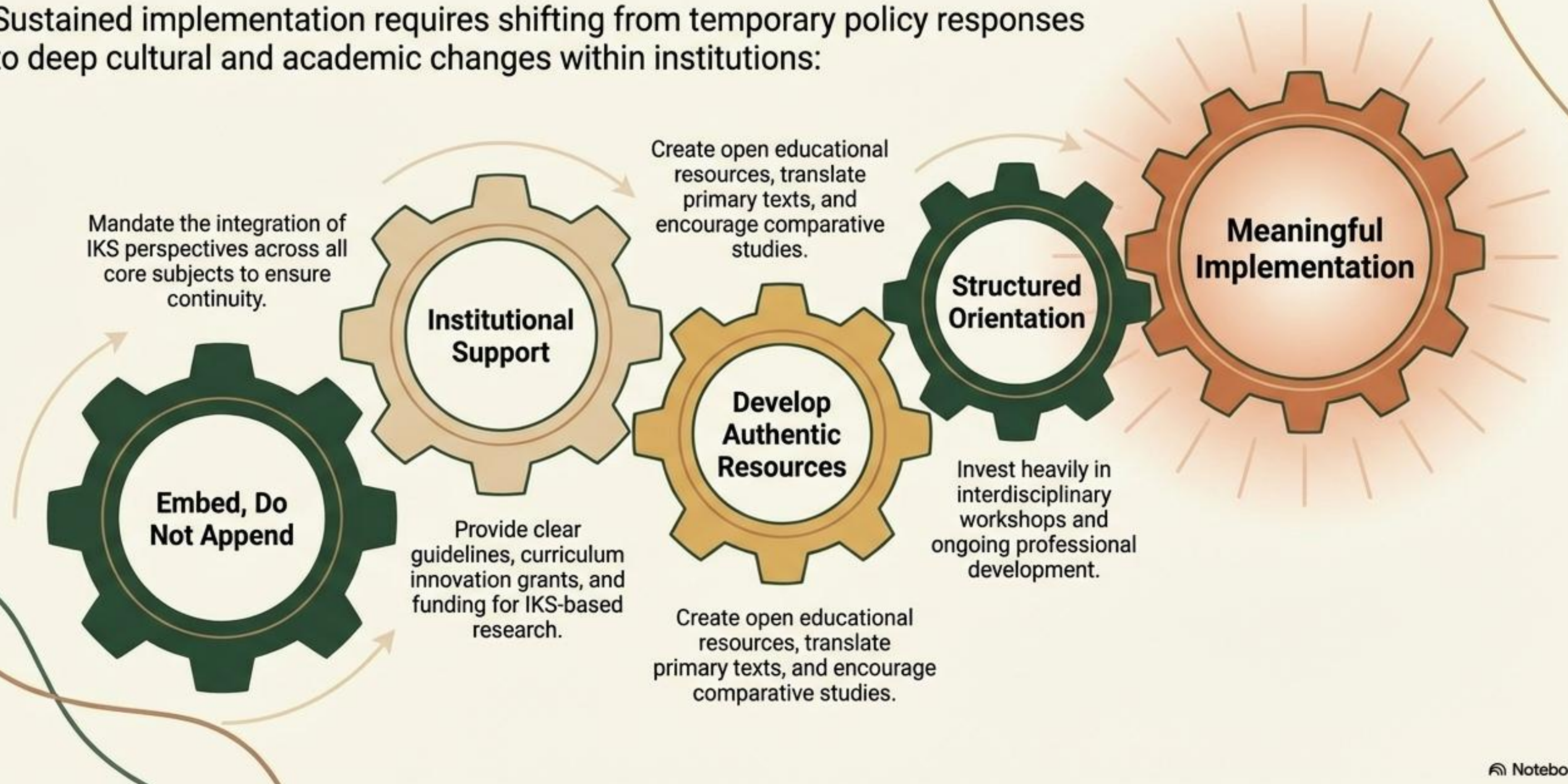
Language Barriers & Resources

Limited availability of translated texts, structured teaching materials, and open educational resources.



Systemic redesign and institutional incentives pave the way forward

Sustained implementation requires shifting from temporary policy responses to deep cultural and academic changes within institutions:



A grounded education system nurtures the whole individual for a global future

Integrating Indian Knowledge Systems in teacher education re-explores the underlying goal of education in India: shaping discipline, ethical awareness, and social responsibility. By giving academic structure to indigenous knowledge and bringing ethical depth to modern pedagogy, we prepare reflective teachers. Rootedness ensures that our education system does not merely produce examination performers, but holistically developed citizens who engage confidently with global ideas from a foundation of deep intellectual heritage.

